# SADE BONILLA

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## Contact

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Google Scholar


## Academic Appointments

| | |
|---|---|
| Assistant Professor, University of Pennsylvania | 2022–present |
| Faculty Research Director, Office of School & Community Engagement | 2024–present |
| Faculty Affiliate, Consortium for Policy Research in Education | 2022–present |
| Assistant Professor, University of Massachusetts Amherst | 2019–2022 |
| Faculty Affiliate, Center for Student Success Research | 2019–2022 |

## Education

Stanford University
- Ph.D., Economics of Education, 2019
- M.A., Economics, 2017

Brown University
- A.M., Urban Education Policy, 2010
- A.B., Public Policy & American Institutions, 2008
- A.B., Education Studies: Policy Concentration, 2008

## Publications

### Peer-Reviewed

10. **Bonilla, S.** & Sparks, D. (2026). Get a Skill, Get a Job, Get Ahead? Evaluating the Effects of Virginia's Workforce-Targeted Free College Program. *Economics of Education Review*. 112, 102798. DOI:10.1016/j.econedurev.2026.102798
    *Impact Factor (2025): 1.8*

9. Bisht, B., **Bonilla, S.**, Kim, H.E., & Penner, E.K. (2026). Cultural Relevance at Scale: The Effects of an Ethnic Studies Expansion on Academic Outcomes. *American Educational Research Journal*.
    *Impact Factor (2024): 3.6*

8. Sparks, D. & **Bonilla, S.** (2025). The Role of Policy Design in Free College Programs: Evidence from Virginia. *Education Finance and Policy*. DOI:10.1162/edfp.a.23.1-15. Supporting info: 9 pages)
    *Impact Factor (2024): 2.0*

7. **Bonilla, S.** & Thim, A. (2025). The Effects of At-Scale Career Pathway Investments on the Transition from High School to College. *Education Finance and Policy*, 20(4), 609-635.
    *Impact Factor (2024): 2.0*

6. **Bonilla, S.**, McDermott, K.A., & Gerstl-Pepin, C. (2022). The Politics of COVID-19 and Educational Inequities. *Peabody Journal of Education*, 97(3), 251256. (6 pages)
    *Impact Factor (2023): 0.835*

5. Dougherty, S.M., Ecton, W.G., **Bonilla, S.**, & McGuinness, S. (2022). COVID-19 and Career Preparation. *Peabody Journal of Education*, 97(3), 326343. (18 pages)
   *Impact Factor (2023): 0.835*

4. **Bonilla, S.**, Dee, T.S., & Penner, E.K. (2021). Ethnic Studies Increases Longer-run Academic Engagement and Attainment. *PNAS*, 118(37), 110. (10 pages; Supporting info: 10 pages)
   *Impact Factor (2024): 9.1*

3. Tseng, A.S., **Bonilla, S.** & MacPherson, A. (2021). Fighting Bad Science in the Information Age. *Journal of Research in Science Teaching*, 58(8), 11521178. (Supporting info: 29 pages)
   *Impact Factor (2024): 4.5*

2. **Bonilla, S.** (2020). The Dropout Effects of Career Pathways: Evidence from California. *Economics of Education Review*, 75, 101972, 1-20. (20 pages, Supporting info: 10 pages)
   *Impact Factor (2023): 1.8*

1. **Bonilla, S.**, & Dee, T. (2020). The Effects of School Reform Under NCLB Waivers: Evidence From Focus Schools in Kentucky. *Education Finance and Policy*, 15(1), 75103. (29 pages; Online appendix: 11 pages)
   *Impact Factor (2024): 2.0*

Book Chapters

1. **Bonilla, S.**, Dougherty, S.M. & Ecton, W.G. (2025). Career and Technical Education: History, Theory, Evidence, and the Path Ahead. In Cohen-Vogel, L., Scott, J., & Youngs, P. (Eds). *Handbook of Education Policy Research*, 2nd Edition.

Under Review

1. **Bonilla, S.**, Dee, T.S., & Pyne, J. (*Revise & Resubmit*). Culturally Relevant Education Discourages Enrollment Loss. *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis*.

2. **Bonilla, S.** & Minaya, V. (*Revise & Resubmit*). Affording to Stay: Experimental Evidence on a Cost-of-Living Grant in Community Colleges. [Pre-registered RCT: doi 10.17605/osf.io/p67cd]. *Education Finance and Policy*.

3. **Bonilla, S.** & Sparks, D. (*Revise & Resubmit*). Aligned Pathways, Unequal Earnings: Gendered Transitions from Community College to Work. *AERA Open*.

4. **Bonilla, S.** (*Revise & Resubmit*). Causal Evidence on High School Ethnic Studies and Civic Participation. *AERA Open*.

Reports

1. **Bonilla, S.**, Dougherty, S.M., & Ecton, W.G. (2026). Career, Technical, and Workforce Education: The State of the Evidence. Report supported by Arnold Ventures.

2. **Bonilla, S.** (2025). The distribution and allocation of teachers in the School District of Philadelphia: Findings and implications for equitable access to high-quality instruction.

3. **Bonilla, S.** (2021). Engagement and attainment: The longer-term causal effects of ethnic studies. Research Snapshot Brief, Student Experience Research Network.

4. **Bonilla, S.**, Carruthers, C.K. & Baker, D.J. (2020). Guidance and Supports for Students Moving into Postsecondary. Annenberg Institute for School Reform Covid-19 Briefs for State and District Policymakers.

### Working Papers

- **Bonilla, S.**, & Minaya, V. (2025). Mental Health and Basic Needs as Barriers to Persistence and Credit Accumulation in Community Colleges. Available as EdWorking Paper 24-925: `https://doi.org/10.26300/0cw6-fe07`
- **Bonilla, S.**, Bennett, E., & Chan, M. (2026). Impacts of Need-Based Financial Aid for Non-Tuition Expenses. [Pre-registered study].

## Funded Research

### External Awards

**Arnold Ventures** $325,248 (PI) 2026–2028
*Funding Pathways to Success: The Policy Impact of Tuition-Free Dual Enrollment on Attainment and Workforce Preparation*

**Neubauer Family Foundation** $1,783,835 (Co-PI) 2025–2029
*Evaluation of the Algebra I Fellowship* in partnership with the School District of Philadelphia

**Spencer Foundation** $49,854 (PI) 2025–2026
*The Causal Effect of Ethnic Studies on Civic Participation and Postsecondary Attainment*

**Lumina Foundation** $48,862 (co-PI) 2025–2026
*Last Mile Funding for the G3 Evaluation*

**Institute for Education Sciences** $2,999,746 [$497,724 subaward] (Co-PI) 2022–2027
*Strengthening Virginia's Pandemic Recovery Efforts: Providing High-Quality Community College Workforce Education to Underserved Adults*
**Note:** Canceled by the Department of Education on March 7, 2025 as part of Title VI enforcement action against Columbia University (prime) and reinstated August 1, 2026

**Arnold Ventures** $360,537 (PI) 2022–2026
*Cost-of-Living Grant Pilot on Community College Student Success*

**William & Flora Hewlett Foundation** $620,000 [$32,840 subaward] (Co-PI) 2021–2024
*Centering Student Voice to Understand the Influence of Ethnic Studies Courses on Students Academic, Behavioral, and Social-Emotional Outcomes: A Cross-Case Mixed Methods Collaboration*

**Mindset Scholars Network** $120,000 (Co-PI) 2019–2020

*The Longer-term Effects of Ethnic Studies*

**Spencer Foundation/NAEd** $27,500 (Dissertation Fellow) 2018–2019
*The Effects of Articulated Career Pathway Reforms for High School Students*

## Internal Awards

**Bridge Funding Program** University of Pennsylvania $13,924 (PI) 2025–2026
*Support to sustain postdoctoral mentorship and research continuity following federal funding disruption.*

**Grants for Faculty Mentoring Undergraduate Research** $8,000 (PI) 2023–2024
*Evaluation of a Cost-of-Living Grant Pilot on Community College & The distribution and allocation of teachers in the School District of Philadelphia*

**Penn Undergraduate Research Mentoring Program (PURM)** $10,000 2022–2023
*Strengthening Virginia's Workforce Pandemic Recovery Efforts*

### UMass Amherst

**Public Service Endowment Grant** UMass Amherst $14,459 2021–2022
*Bridging the Gap to College During Covid-19*

**Faculty Research Grant/Healey Grant** UMass Amherst $19,179 2021–2022
*The Causal Effects of Career Pathways on Educational Attainment*

## Honors & Awards

Postsecondary Education & Economics Research (PEER) Center 2026
*Summer Scholar (selected participant)*

Public Engagement Project, UMass Amherst 2021–2022
*Fellowship recipient: $1,000*

ADVANCE Mutual Mentoring Grant, UMass Amherst 2021–2022
*Award recipient: $5,500*

Association for Education Finance & Policy 2021–2022
*Early Career Program Participant*

Faculty Success Fellows Program, UMass Amherst 2020–2021
*Fellowship recipient: $2,950*

Outstanding Predoctoral Award, Institute for Education Sciences (IES) 2019
*Award recipient*

Emerging Education Policy Scholar 2018–2019
*Fellowship recipient*

UC Presidents Postdoctoral Fellowship Program 2018
*Postdoctotal Fellow Semi-finalist*

Karr Family Fellowship Program 2016–2018
*Fellowship recipient*

APPAM Equity and Inclusion Fellowship 2016

*Fellowship recipient*

Predoctoral Training Program, Institute of Educational Sciences (IES) 2013–2016
*Pre-doctoral Fellow*

Fulbright Fellowship, U.S. Department of State 2009
*Fellow, Chile*

## Presentations

### Invited Talks

University of Delaware (*invited*) 2026
Pontificia Universidad Catolica de Chile (*invited*)
New America (*policy think tank*)
Arnold Ventures
Southern Methodist University

Princeton University 2025
Texas A&M University
School District of Philadelphia

MA Commission on Higher Education Quality & Affordability 2024
U.S. Department of Education
Boston University
Virginia Community College System
University of Wisconsin–Madison
Harvard Graduate School of Education

Massachusetts Commission of Higher Education 2023
RAND Corporation
Brown University
Brookings Institute

San Diego State University 2022
University of Chicago
CALDER (Center for Analysis of Longitudinal Data in Education Research)

University of Pennsylvania 2021
D.C. State Board of Education
Espacio Publico  Chile
SUNY Albany
Council of Chief State School Officers (CCSSO)
Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation
San Francisco Unified School District
Santa Clara University
Holyoke Public Schools (MA)

Urban Institute 2020

Mindset Scholars Network

Montana State University 2019

University of Washington, Seattle 2018
Saint Louis University
University of Florida
University of Massachusetts Amherst

## Peer-Reviewed

Higher Education Finance Research Conference, Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia (Philadelphia, PA, 2026); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (Los Angeles, 2026); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Chicago, 2026); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Chicago, 2026); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Seattle, 2025); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (Denver, 2025); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Washington D.C., 2025); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (National Harbor, 2024); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Baltimore, 2024); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Atlanta, 2023); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Denver, 2023); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Washington D.C., 2022); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (San Diego, 2022); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Denver, 2022); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Virtual, 2021); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Virtual, 2020); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Virtual, 2020); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Denver, 2019); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Kansas City, 2019); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Washington D.C., 2016); Association for Education Finance and Policy, Spring Conference (Washington D.C., 2016); Graduate School of Education (Stanford, CA, 2016); Association for Education Finance and Policy,Spring Conference (San Antonio, TX, 2014); American Educational Research Association Annual Meeting (San Francisco, CA, 2013); Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Fall Conference (Baltimore, MD, 2012)

## Teaching

**University of Pennsylvania**

| | |
|---|---|
| Education Policy Foundations (graduate) | 2026 |
| Economic Perspectives on Higher Education Policy (masters) | 2026 |
| Inquiry Fundamentals for Education Policy (masters) | 2025–2026 |

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| Education Policy Research Practicum (masters) | 2023–2025 |
| Advanced Causal Inference Research and Reporting (doctoral) | 2022, 2023 |

**University of Massachusetts Amherst**

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|---|---|
| Economics of Education (graduate) | 2020, 2021 |
| Economics of Education (undergraduate) | 2021 |
| Higher Education Policy (graduate) | 2019–2021 |
| Causal Inference in Educational Research (graduate) | 2021 |

## Advising

***Doctoral Advising***

**Primary Advisor:**

Evan Bennett (Penn GSE, Ph.D. in-progress)
Jennifer Benavides (Penn GSE Ed.D., Chair, in-progress)

**Committee Member:**

Margot Todman-Mack (Penn GSE Ed.D., defended 5/2025)
Susan E. Thompson (Penn GSE Ed.D., defended 5/2023)
Catherine Park (UMass Amherst Ph.D., defended 4/2023)
Jonathon Montoya (UC Irvine Ph.D., defended 8/2022)

***Postdoctoral Advising***

Brittany Vasquez, Ph.D.
Daniel Sparks, Ph.D. [Placement: University of Arkansas]

***Undergraduate Advising***

Samantha Salcedo (Penn SAS, Media & Urban Studies, exp. 2025)
*Pre-doctoral Diversity Fellow AEFP, 2024*
Dedeepya Guthikonda (Penn SAS, Economics, exp. 2026)
*Equity & Inclusion Fellow APPAM, 2023*
Michael Fuentes (Penn SAS, Economics, exp. 2026)
*Equity & Inclusion Fellow APPAM, 2023*
Allan Lee (Penn SAS, Economics 2023)
*Pre-doctoral Diversity Fellow AEFP 2023*

## Service

***University of Pennsylvania***

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|---|---|
| Executive Committee (School)<br>*Member* | 2025–2026 |
| Ad Hoc Committee on Community Engaged Scholarship<br>*Member* | 2024–2026 |
| Policy, Organizations, Leadership & Systems Doctoral Seminar<br>*Co-Instructor* | 2022–2023 |
| Education Policy Doctoral Admissions<br>*Committee Member* | 2023, 2024 |

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| Pre-tenure Faculty Writing and Accountability Group<br>*Co-organizer and Member* | 2022–present |
| Causal Inference Working Groups<br>*Member* | 20222023 |

***University of Massachusetts Amherst***

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|---|---|
| Department Academic Matters Committee (Department)<br>*Committee Member* | 2021–2022 |
| Public Service Endowment Grants Reviewer (University)<br>*Ad-hoc Reviewer* | Spring 2020 |
| Scholarship Selection Committee (College)<br>*Committee Member* | Spring 2020 |
| AQAD Undergraduate Education Committee (Department)<br>*Committee Member* | Spring 2020 |
| Ph.D. Admissions (Department)<br>*Committee Member* | 2019–2020 |
| M.Ed/MPPA Admissions (Department)<br>*Committee Member* | 2020–2021 |

## Referee Service

**Reviewer for Journals**

*Journal for Research on Educational Effectiveness; Journal of Policy Analysis and Management; Economics of Education Review; Education Finance and Policy; Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis; American Education Research Journal; AERA Open; Education Researcher; Journal of Labor Economics; Journal of Higher Education.*

**Editorial Board Member:**

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| *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis* | 2025 – present |
| *AERA Open* | 2020 – 2021 |

## Professional Associations

**Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)**

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|---|---|
| Co-Chair, Education Section | 2024, 2025 |
| Reviewer, Education Section | 2022– 2025 |
| Reviewer, Equity & Inclusion Fellowship | 2023 |

**Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)**

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| Reviewer, Spring Conference | 2023– 2026 |

**American Educational Research Association (AERA)**

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|---|---|
| Reviewer, Spring Conference | 2023 |

## Media Mentions

Harkay, J. (2026, July 14). Can ethnic studies bridge the achievement gap? San Francisco program shows gains. The 74 Million.

Johnson, G. (2026, July 10). Taking ethnic studies courses increases academic performance. Penn Today.

Tribune News Report (2026, May 1). New study finds ethnic studies linked to higher GPAs for Black, Latino students. Philadelphia Tribune

Sleeter, C. (2025, April 22) California leaders must keep their promise by funding ethnic studies. EdSource

Sellery, K. (2024, Winter). Bridging the gap: How career technical education unites job training and academics. California Schools.

Strauss, V. (2023, June 8) What it really takes to help students succeed. Washington Post.

Rebar, S. (2023, February 3) Sade Bonilla studies how to engage high school students. Penn GSE News.

Smith, E. (2023, February 3). Examining college enrollment gaps: A discussion with leading scholars. Brookings Institute.

Wiener, R. & Lopez, F. (2022, March 29). Ignoring racism in schools actually increases prejudice. Education Week.

Lunn, B. (2022, February 22). IES honors Sade Bonilla as 2019 Outstanding Predoctoral Fellow. Inside IES Research.

Saldaña, C. (2021, October 19). National Education Policy Center Talks Education. NEPC.

Mays, M. (2021, October 14). California students will have to take ethnic studies to get a diploma. Politico.

Speakman, K. (2021, October 8) California requires ethnic studies for high school students. Forbes.

Fensterwalk, J. (2021, September 7) Research finds ethnic studies in San Francisco had enduring impact. EdSource.

Spector, C. (2019, May 15). Schools that received state funds to expand career training programs saw lower dropout rates, Stanford researcher finds. Stanford.